

[Return to Search](#)

Dancing histories

Author(S): McCall, John C. (John Christensen)

Document Type: Book

Original Page: 34

Culture (OWC): [Igbo \(FF26\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Western Africa

Field Date: 1989-1996

Coverage Date: 1989-1996

Place Coverage: Ohafia, Nigeria

Section Title(S): A Passage

Nna Nduka's compound was in a newer section of Akanu named *Faith* by the missionaries who established it. The cool of the morning was giving way to the heat of midday by the time we trekked past the small contiguous huts of the old village toward the outlying settlements of new homes, many with second stories and spacious inner courtyards. We found Nna Nduka's compound crowded with people dressed in fine clothing: men in heavy velvet shirts and madras wrappers, women wrapped in bright imported cloth from India and Holland. As we entered the yard we were quickly ushered in to view the deceased. Nna Nduka's body was displayed in a coffin in a small room packed with women. When I looked at this skeletal cadaver with cotton in its nose I could not recognize the man whom I had seen, alive and jovial, just a few weeks before. I found it difficult to concentrate on responding correctly to the profusion of greetings because, even though I had attended many of these events, I had never learned to be casual in the presence of a corpse.

123
[Observation In Research](#)

361
[Settlement Patterns](#)

362
[Housing](#)

764
[Burial Practices And Funerals](#)

We moved into a large room filled with men and women chatting and drinking. No beer or palm wine seemed to be forthcoming and I was resolved to avoid gin, so I deflected the shot glass as it was passed, touching it to acknowledge the hosts' generosity but sending it on its way. Nna Nduka's eldest son, the primary sponsor of the event, sat sipping gin, and Ink kept directing barbed remarks at him. At first I wondered if this indicated some sort of traditional "joking relationship" but I discovered later that Ink was furious with his wealthy relative for the paucity of the preparations. If this first burial ceremony was to be such a meager event, then what, worried Ink, would the second burial be like? The second burial was customarily held many months, sometimes years, following the death of an important individual. The delay allowed family members time to raise funds for an event splendid enough

123
[Observation In Research](#)

443
[Retail Marketing](#)

576
[Etiquette](#)

578
[Ingroup Antagonisms](#)

to be an appropriate tribute to the deceased. Ink asked when the second burial would be held. The elder son responded that he would hold it in August. Ink insisted that no one would be around in August during “*anwu*”—the time of scarcity before harvest when much of the population migrates to urban residences. Ink proposed the ceremony should be planned for December when everyone returns for Christmas festivities. “I often travel in December because I am frequently invited to visit good friends in ³⁵distant places at that time,” came the curt reply. Ink coolly countered: “Then you must invite those good friends to Ohafia to attend the burial of your own father!” This retort was met with silence, and Ink continued with the provocation, “or perhaps you should hold the ceremony after *izu at* [eight days].”⁵ This provocation was ironic; it would be impossible to produce an adequate second burial ceremony in such a short time. The switch from reference to the Roman calendar to Ohafia time reckoning was significant. *Izu at* has significance as an indigenous measurement of ceremonial time. To speak of it in this context, when the man's adherence to traditional obligations was in question, was to twist a rhetorical knife. Unable to counter Ink's offensive he mumbled something about the possibility of a December ceremony and then quickly tried to change the subject.

764
Burial Practices And
Funerals

765
Mourning

805
Ordering Of Time

5. The Igbo market week (*izu*) has four days. These weeks are further categorized into two types designating greater and lesser markets that alternate so that the full market cycle is eight days. In most of Igboland this period is referred to as *izu abba* (two weeks). In Ohafia dialect this phrase is meaningless. The Ohafia refer to this period as *izu at* (three weeks). It appears that this system of enumeration counts the number of markets rather than the number of weeks.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)